

« As an athlete, you have to be honest with yourself »

MO FARAH

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A young and lonely Mo Farah found a friend in athletics when he arrived in the United Kingdom at the age of nine, after being trafficked from Djibouti in East Africa.

It wasn't an easy journey, but with sheer dedication, he went on to achieve what few could even imagine — four Olympic gold medals, six World Championships, and multiple European Championship titles. He also achieved the rare feat of consecutive Olympic long-distance doubles — in London 2012 and Rio 2016.

Even after transitioning to marathons in 2017, the legendary athlete made his presence felt. He believes it's important for athletes to let go of failures, take things in their stride, and start afresh every time.

In conversation with *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the Mumbai Marathon, the global icon spoke at length on a range of topics, starting from his early days to how India can develop world-class athletes.

Thoughts on coming to Mumbai for the marathon...

It's really exciting to be here in India, especially in Mumbai as an ambassador for the Tata Mumbai Marathon. This is my first time in the city. I have a lot of friends who always talk about Mumbai.

But it's my first time actually seeing it in person — the people, the culture. It's unbelievable. I get a warm feeling from being here.

Do you follow Indian athletics closely?

Yes, you have so many athletes who are coming along and improving. You've got the world champion in javelin (Neeraj Chopra). There are a few guys in the 800m and 1500m.

The Indian record in the marathon is 2:12:00 (by Shivnath Singh), so there are athletes who are closing that gap. I believe India has great potential for its youth and programmes in place. I learned from the best, training with the Kenyans and Ethiopians. I've come across so many athletes who are willing to go that extra mile, which is a great attitude to have.

You spoke about Chopra. How

does a country benefit when there's a role model to look up to?

It's really important for athletes to have a role model — someone they look up to who's been competing with the best, who's a world champion, an Olympic champion. He's a great role model for youth and younger athletes.

When you're young and questioning yourself about how to do it, you see them doing it every time and becoming the best in the world. That should answer all the questions and doubts you have. If they can do it, so can we.

What's the right age for an athlete to transition from the track to road races?

When we talk about 1500m, 5000m, and 10,000m, that's track and field. Then you've got the marathon, which is 42 kilometres (26.2 miles). Athletes tend to move to marathons as they approach the end of their track career, when they no longer have the same speed.

When I moved to marathons after the World Championships in 2017, was that the right time? Was it a good age to do it? Among other